

U1 · INTERNATIONAL RELATIONS × EDUCATION

They called it an insulator. *I study the current.*

I'm Nimra Zahid, an International Relations researcher and educator. My research asks what changes when Afghanistan is read not as a buffer between regions, but as a driver of their security.

MA IR (Merit) · MPhil IR · Educator since 2015 · Northampton, UK

Follow the current →

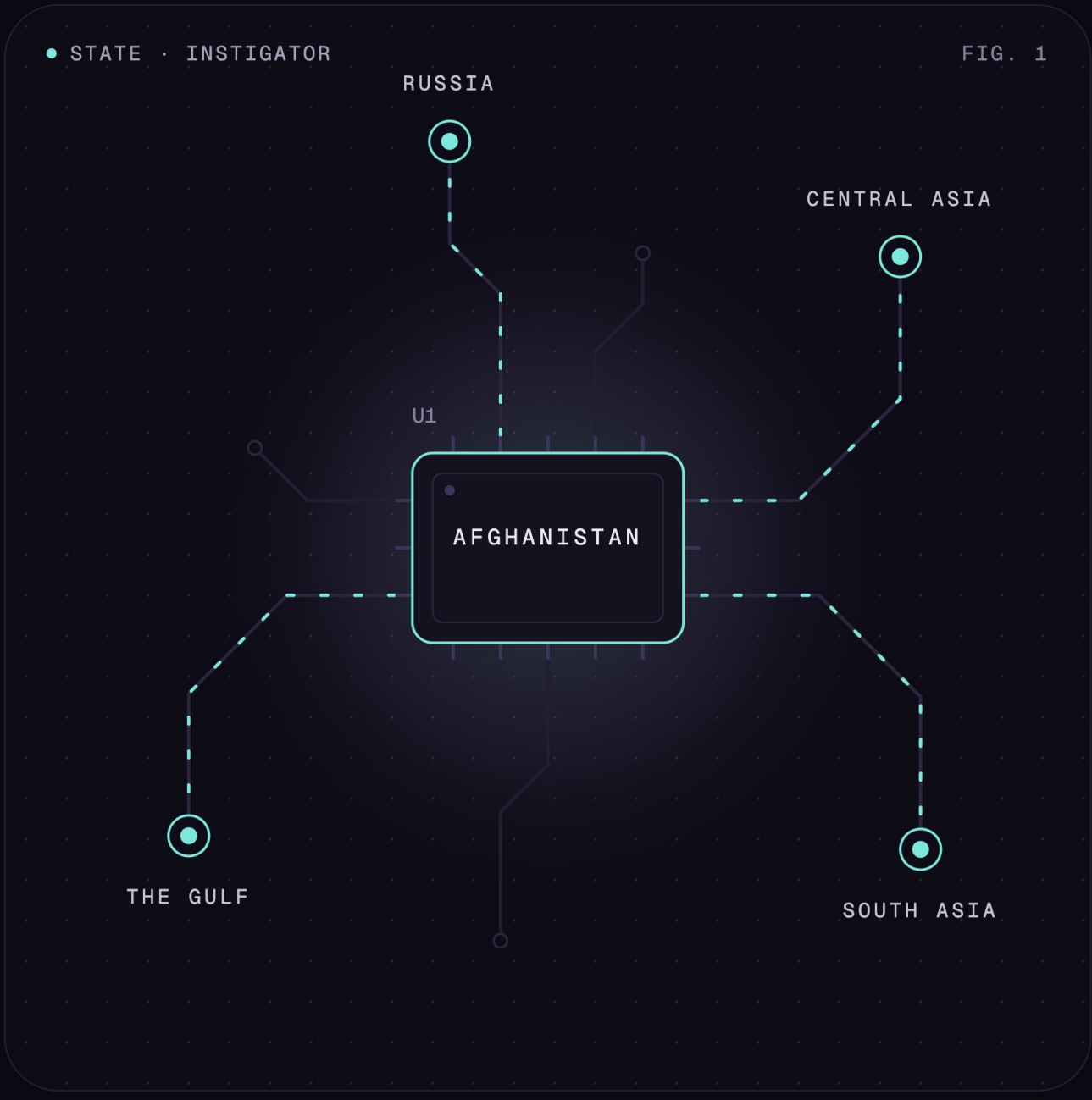
Download CV

READ AFGHANISTAN AS

⌕ Insulator

→ Instigator

My reading: Afghanistan generates security dynamics that travel outward into the complexes around it.



Current flowing outward from U1 Abstract diagram · not geographic boundaries

READOUT 01

10+

years in education

READOUT 02

2

countries taught in

READOUT 03

3

degrees in International Relations

READOUT 04

6

undergraduate modules taught

J1 · TWO STRANDS, ONE CIRCUIT

Research and teaching run on the same current.

A little more about me →



R1 · RESEARCH

Regional security & Afghanistan

I ask why Afghanistan should be understood as an instigator, not simply an insulator, in its regional security complex.

RSCT

South & Central Asia

Qualitative case study

Explore the argument →



T1 · TEACHING

Teaching, inclusion & possibility

Over ten years teaching across Pakistan and England, from undergraduate International Relations to specialist SEMH provision.

KS3-4 Geography & History

SEMH

Undergraduate IR

My approach to teaching →

SHARED TERMINAL · CONTEXT: HOW RELATIONSHIPS SHAPE WHAT WE SEE AND LEARN

J2 · SIGNAL PATH

From insulator to *instigator*.

Each project carries the same question a step further.

View all research →

2018

2020

2024

NEXT

MPHIL THESIS · NDU ISLAMABAD

Russia, Afghanistan & regional stability

How Russia–Afghanistan relations shape stability across the wider region.

Project overview →

CONFERENCE PAPER · ISTANBUL

Afghanistan, Turkey & the Global War on Terror

Presented at the Istanbul International Social Science Conference, June 2020.

Project overview →

MA DISSERTATION · MERIT

Deconstructing Afghanistan's role in RSCT

Challenges the "insulator" label and reads Afghanistan as an instigator of regional security dynamics.

Project overview →

DOCTORAL RESEARCH · PLANNED

Testing the instigator thesis

Taking the argument into a doctoral project on Afghanistan and regional security.

Discuss supervision →

J3 · LATEST WRITING

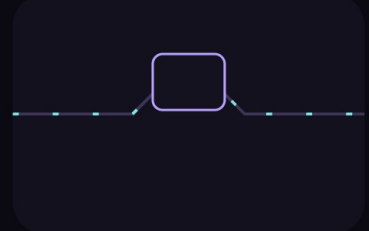
Notes from the circuit.

All writing →

RSCT · 7 MIN READ · [PUBLISH DATE]

Why Afghanistan is not a buffer

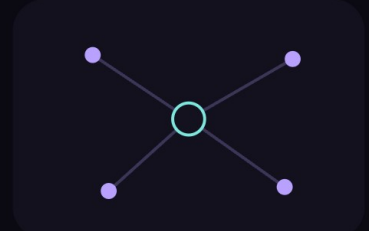
A plain-language guide to Regional Security Complex Theory, and the classification my research sets out to challenge.



REGIONAL SECURITY · DRAFT

Afghanistan's neighbours, re-wired

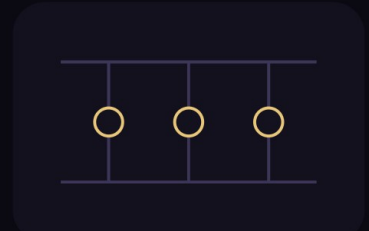
Commentary on how security dynamics travel outward from Afghanistan into the regions around it.



TEACHING · DRAFT

Teaching geopolitics with care

What specialist SEMH classrooms have taught me about explaining a complicated world.



SWITCH OPEN · AWAITING YOU

Complete the *circuit*.

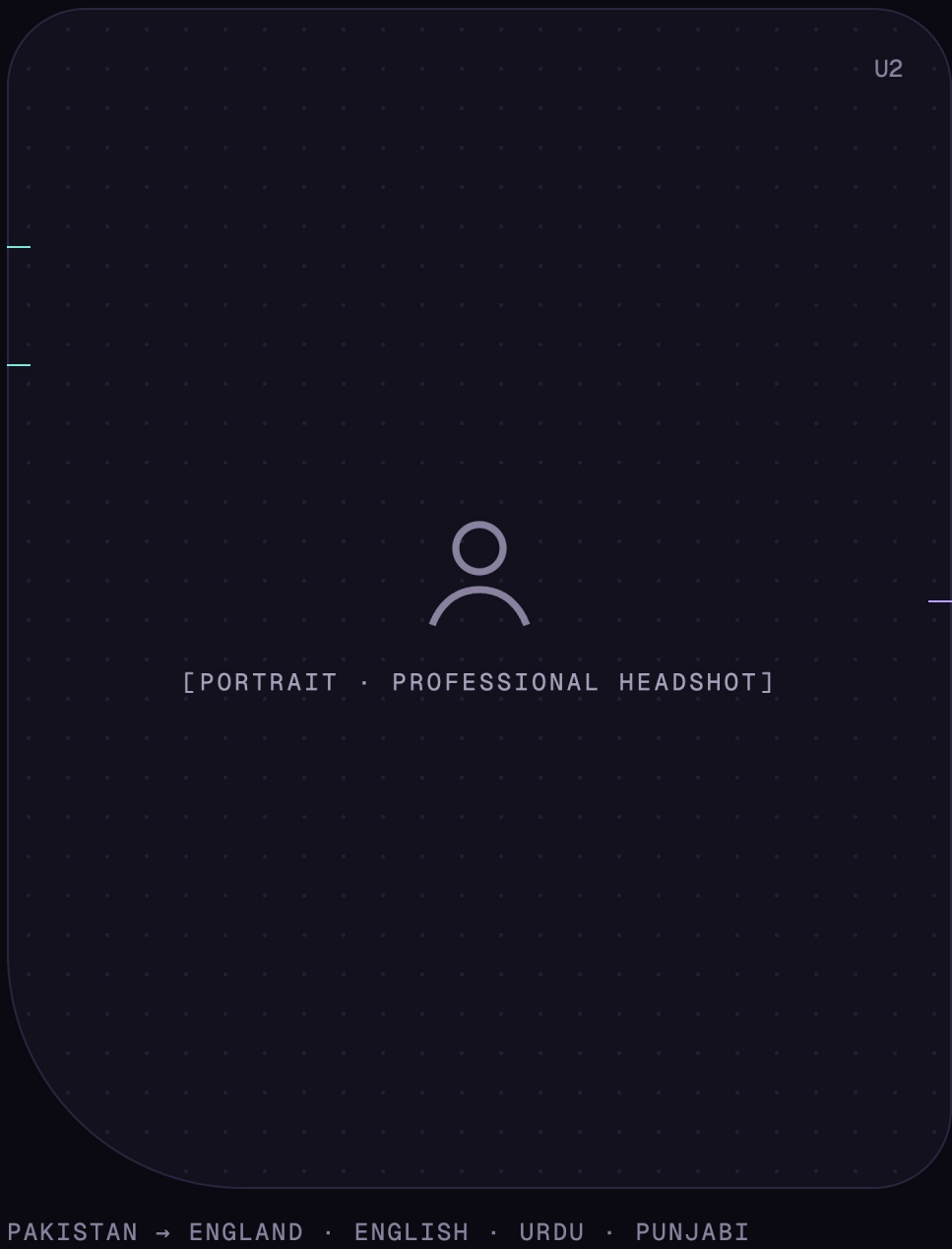
Open to doctoral research opportunities, collaboration and speaking.

Start a conversation

View CV

⚙

Contact



U2 · ABOUT

A researcher’s
curiosity. *An educator’s
perspective.*

My academic and teaching journey connects Lahore, Mandi Bahauddin, Islamabad and Northampton. Across those places, International Relations has given me a way to examine how regions connect, while teaching has kept my attention on how people learn to understand those connections.

I studied International Relations at Lahore College for Women University and the National Defence University in Islamabad, before completing an MA with Merit at the University of Northampton in 2024.

Alongside that research, I have taught Humanities and Social Studies in Pakistan, lectured in undergraduate International Relations, and taught Geography, History and Science in England. I now teach in specialist SEMH education in Northamptonshire.

My research and teaching share a concern with context: how relationships shape what we see, what we learn and what becomes possible.

J1 · THE ROUTE SO FAR

Five places, one line of inquiry.



J2 · ACADEMIC RECORD

Three degrees in
International
Relations.

Full CV →

2023 - 2024	MA International Relations University of Northampton	MERIT
2016 - 2018	MPhil International Relations National Defence University, Islamabad	CGPA 3.53 / 4.00
2011 - 2015	BS International Relations Lahore College for Women University	CGPA 3.24 / 4.00

J3 · PRINCIPLES

Knowledge should *conduct.*

P1

Accessible knowledge

I aim to connect rigorous ideas with clear explanation, in research and in the classroom.

P2

Inclusion & mentorship

My teaching is attentive to different learning needs, with wellbeing as a foundation for participation.

P3

Community engagement

At the University of Gujrat, I coordinated student welfare as Student Affairs Sub-in-Charge and led the Blood Donation Society.

METHODS & TOOLS

Qualitative case study

Theory-driven analysis (RSCT)

Practitioner reflection

SPSS

Research ethics · NIH training

LANGUAGES

English

Urdu

Punjabi

Nimra Zahid

International Relations researcher and educator. Northampton, UK.

EXPLORE

- About
- Research
- Teaching
- Writing

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DOCUMENTS

- Download CV (PDF)
- RSS feed
- Degree verification on request

U3 · RESEARCH · REGIONAL SECURITY

Rethinking Afghanistan's regional role.

I study how Afghanistan shapes the security of the regions around it: not only as a buffer, but as a driver.

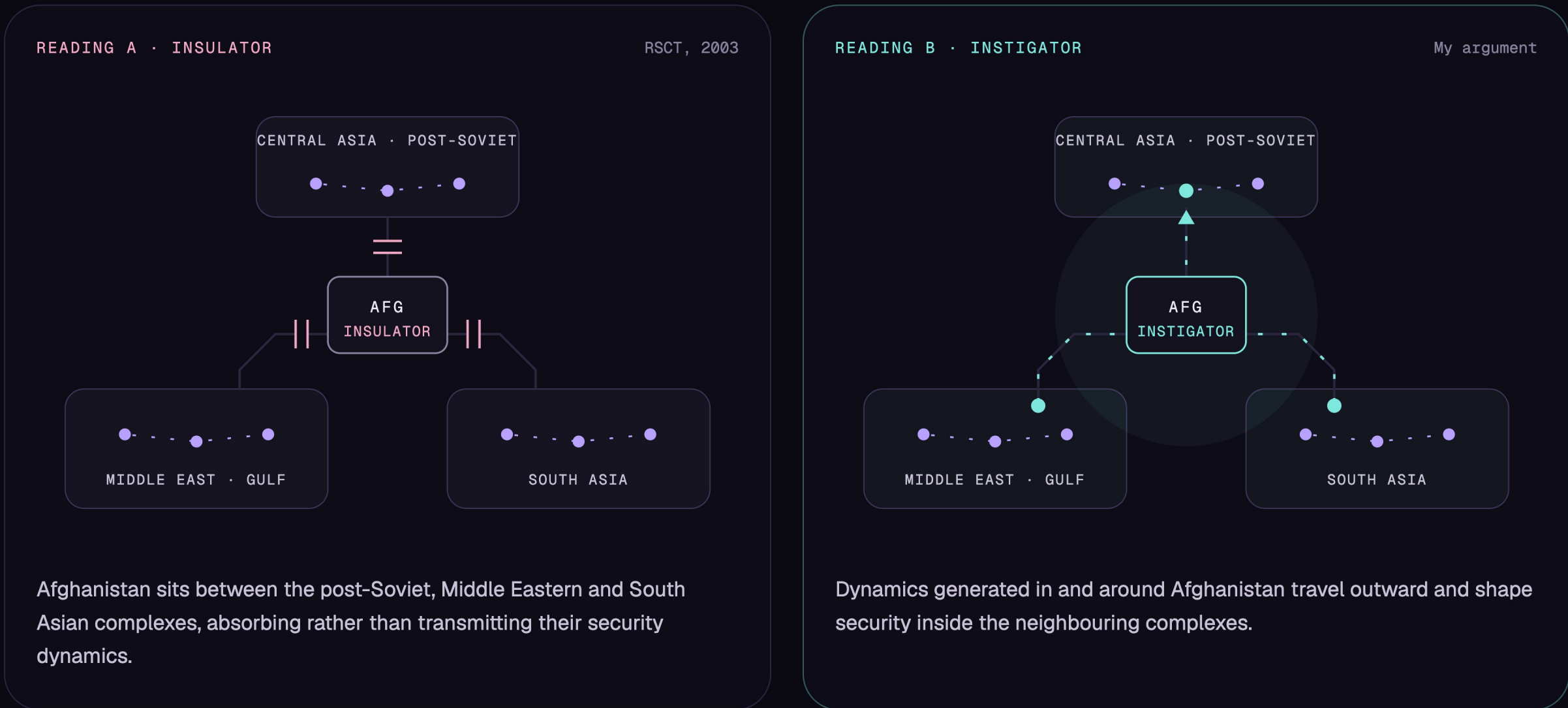
A question that connects my work.

Regional Security Complex Theory offers a way to understand the security relationships that connect neighbouring states. In it, Afghanistan is classed as an insulator: a state on the edge of several complexes that keeps their dynamics apart.

My research asks what changes when Afghanistan is understood instead as an active force in those relationships. From Russia–Afghanistan relations to the wider regional effects of the Global War on Terror, I am building an agenda around the connections between South Asia, Central Asia and their neighbours.

FIG. 2 · TWO READINGS OF THE SAME BOARD

After Buzan & Weaver, Regions and Powers (2003) · abstract diagram, not a map



J1 · OUTPUTS

Three projects on one trace.

2024

MA DISSERTATION

Deconstructing the Role of Afghanistan in Regional Security Complex Theory

MERIT

[Read overview →](#)

Challenges Afghanistan's classification as an insulator and examines it as a driver of regional security dynamics.

UNIVERSITY OF NORTHAMPTON · RSCT · THEORY-DRIVEN ANALYSIS

2020

CONFERENCE PAPER

Afghanistan, Turkey & the Global War on Terror

PRESENTED

[Read overview →](#)

Research on the Global War on Terror and the roles of Afghanistan and Turkey in regional security.

ISTANBUL INTERNATIONAL SOCIAL SCIENCE CONFERENCE · ISTANBUL SABAHATTIN ZAIM UNIVERSITY · JUNE 2020

2018

MPHIL THESIS

Russia–Afghanistan relations and regional stability

THESIS · GRADE A

[Read overview →](#)

Examines Russia–Afghanistan relations and their implications for regional stability: the foundation of my continuing work.

NATIONAL DEFENCE UNIVERSITY, ISLAMABAD

J2 · EMERGING INTERESTS

Research-informed, inclusive education.

I am also interested in the relationship between research and practice in specialist social, emotional and mental health (SEMH) education, building on my experience in the classroom.

[Explore my teaching practice →](#)

J3 · TALKS

JUNE 2020 · ISTANBUL, TURKEY

Istanbul International Social Science Conference

Paper presentation · Afghanistan, Turkey and regional security

 Guest lectures and CPD sessions will appear here.

Working on regional security?

I welcome conversations about doctoral research, collaboration and speaking.

[Discuss this research](#)

Nimra Zahid

International Relations researcher and educator. Northampton, UK.

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← All research

MA DISSERTATION · 2024 · UNIVERSITY OF NORTHAMPTON **MERIT**

Deconstructing the Role of Afghanistan in Regional Security Complex Theory

I examine Afghanistan as a driver of regional security dynamics, rather than a buffer between neighbouring security complexes.

01 · ABSTRACT

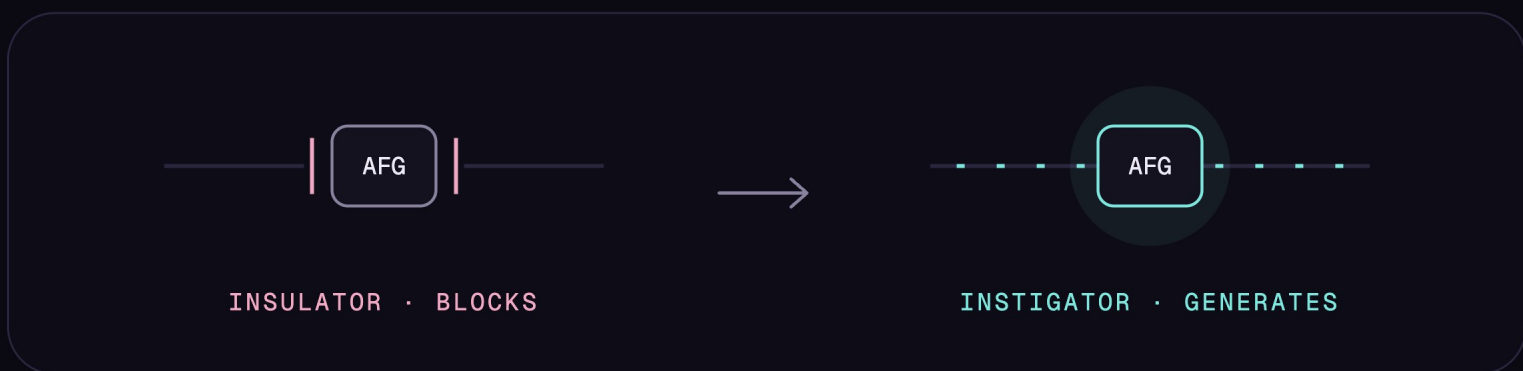
[ABSTRACT · 150–250 words, from the dissertation]

02 · THE QUESTION

How does Afghanistan shape the security relationships of the regions around it?

03 · THE ARGUMENT

Regional Security Complex Theory classifies Afghanistan as an “insulator”: a state that sits between complexes and keeps their dynamics apart. My research challenges that classification and explores Afghanistan’s role as an “instigator” of regional security dynamics.



04 · APPROACH

Theory-driven analysis using Regional Security Complex Theory (RSCT).

[Sources, cases and period examined · 2–3 sentences]

05 · KEY FINDINGS

F1 [Finding one, in one sentence]

F2 [Finding two, in one sentence]

F3 [Finding three, in one sentence]

06 · WHY IT MATTERS & WHAT COMES NEXT

[Why the reclassification matters, and how it leads into the doctoral project · 2–3 sentences]

 This page is a research overview. The full dissertation is not published here; I'm happy to discuss it.

CONNECTED WORK

← EARLIER · MPHIL THESIS · 2018

Russia–Afghanistan relations and regional stability

PLAIN-LANGUAGE VERSION · ESSAY

Why Afghanistan is not a buffer →

Questions about this research?

Discuss this research

Nimra Zahid

International Relations researcher and educator. Northampton, UK.

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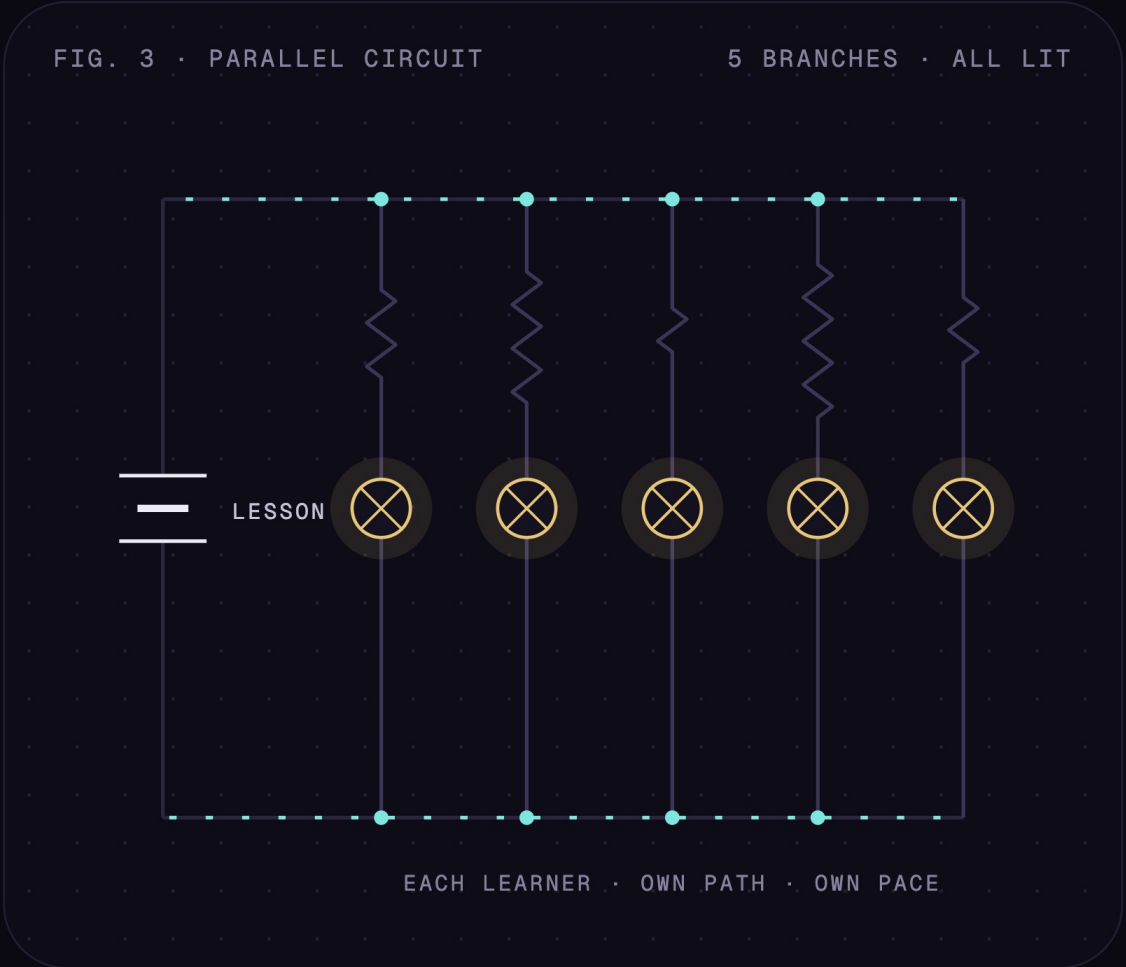
U4 · TEACHING · INCLUSION & PRACTICE

Understanding begins *with belonging.*

Over ten years of teaching across Pakistan and England, from university seminars to specialist secondary education.

Teaching experience

Full CV



Parallel, not series: every learner has their own path to the current, so one branch dimming never switches off the rest.

J1 · PHILOSOPHY

My approach to the classroom.

I see teaching as making knowledge accessible without losing its complexity. Whether I am introducing a theory of international relations or helping a class understand a geographical connection, I begin with what learners already know and the support they need to take the next step.

Adapting to individual needs means thinking carefully about resources, pace and the ways learners can show their understanding. Assessment is most useful when it provides evidence for what to do next, rather than simply a judgement of what has already happened.

My work in specialist social, emotional and mental health provision has strengthened my attention to wellbeing as a foundation for learning. Predictability, trust and an inclusive classroom are central to that approach.

I am interested in how research can inform these everyday decisions, and how reflection on practice can generate better questions.

J2 · TEACHING EXPERIENCE

Four roles, two countries.

FEB 2025 - NOW
T4 · NORTHAMPTONSHIRE

Geography & History Teacher · Form Tutor

Specialist SEMH school, Northamptonshire

- Teach Geography and History across Key Stages 3–4, adapting lessons to pupils' emotional and learning needs.
- Form Tutor for a designated group: pastoral care, wellbeing and daily routines.
- Work with the SENCO and pastoral colleagues; maintain progress records and contribute to termly reviews.
- Regular parent liaison on each pupil's day: engagement, behaviour, achievements and concerns.

FEB 2024 - FEB 2025
T3 · NORTHAMPTON

Geography & Science Teacher

Abbeyfield School, Northampton · via Teaching Personnel

- Planned and delivered secondary Geography and Science, adapting resources to pupils' needs.
- Assessed work and used progress information to shape subsequent teaching.

SEP 2019 - MAR 2022
T2 · MANDI BAHAUDDIN

Visiting Faculty · International Relations

University of Gujrat, Mandi Bahauddin campus

- Taught six undergraduate modules through lectures and seminars.
- Student Affairs Sub-in-Charge: student welfare, departmental liaison and student-facing policy.
- Led the Blood Donation Society, connecting students with the wider university community.

SEP 2015 - MAR 2023
T1 · MANDI BAHAUDDIN

Secondary Teacher · Humanities & Social Studies

Beaconhouse School System, Pakistan · held alongside the university role, 2019–22

- Delivered secondary humanities and social studies across multiple campuses.
- Prepared student reports and contributed to curriculum planning.

J3 · UNIVERSITY TEACHING · UNIVERSITY OF GUJRAT

Six undergraduate modules.

- M1 International Relations

M2 Foreign Policy Analysis

M3 Research Methodology

M4 [Module title]

M5 [Module title]

M6 [Module title]

J4 · SPECIALISMS

Inclusive, pastoral, planned.

- KS3–4 Geography & History

Adapting learning for SEMH needs

Curriculum & resource design

Exam preparation

Progress monitoring

Parent communication

Work with SENCO & pastoral teams

Research-methods teaching



[Short referee quote on reflective practice, used with written permission]

[REFEREE NAME] · [ROLE, INSTITUTION]

Research that starts in the classroom.

Interested in research-informed practice in SEMH education? Let's talk.

Start a conversation

Nimra Zahid

International Relations researcher and educator. Northampton, UK.

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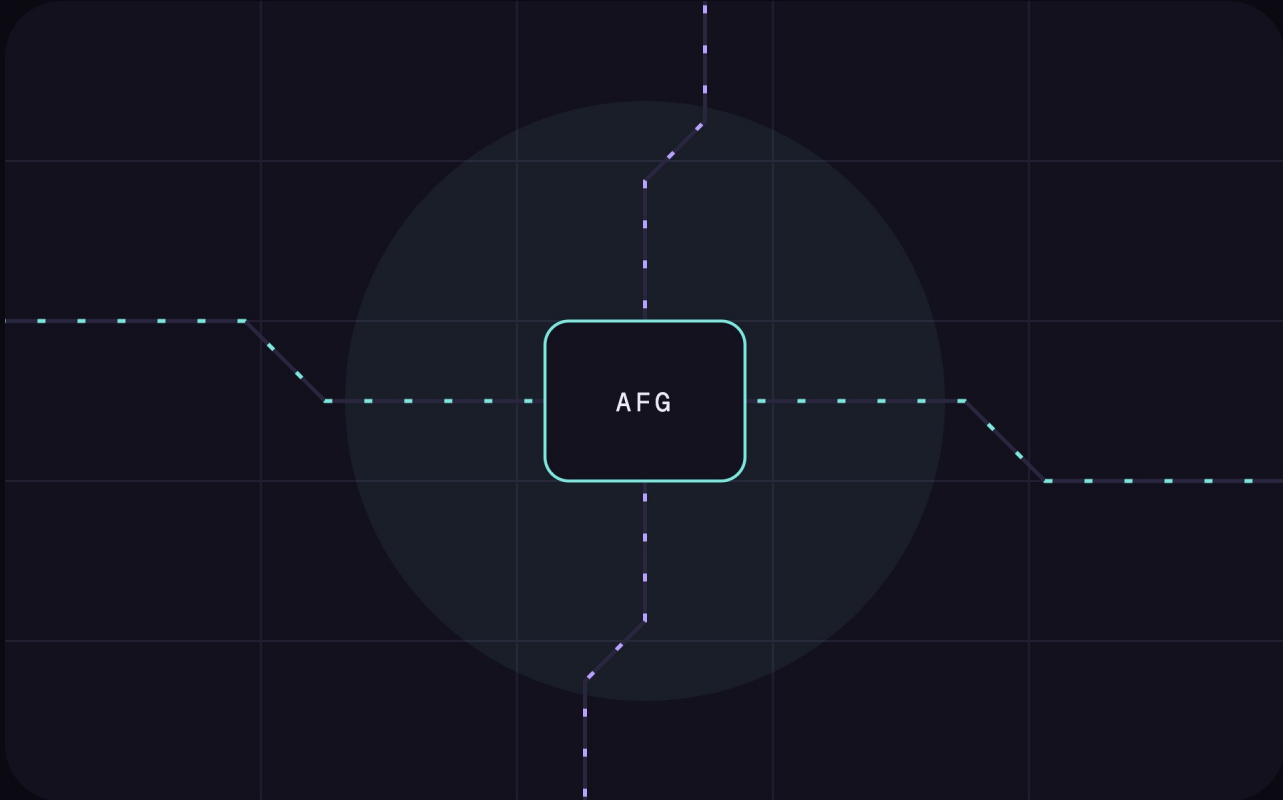
Notes from *the circuit*.

Accessible essays on regional security, Afghanistan and inclusive education.

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Why Afghanistan is not a buffer

A plain-language guide to Regional Security Complex Theory, and the classification my research sets out to challenge.

[nz](#) Nimra Zahid · 7 min read · [PUBLISH DATE][LATEST](#)[RSCT](#) · [7 min read](#) · [PUBLISH DATE]

Why Afghanistan is not a buffer

A plain-language guide to Regional Security Complex Theory, and the classification my research sets out to challenge.

[REGIONAL SECURITY](#) · [SERIES PART 2](#) · [DRAFT](#)

Afghanistan's neighbours, re-wired

Commentary on how security dynamics travel outward from Afghanistan into the regions around it.

[TEACHING](#) · [REFLECTION](#) · [DRAFT](#)

Teaching geopolitics with care

What specialist SEMH classrooms have taught me about explaining a complicated world.

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Understanding Afghanistan's neighbourhood

- ☒ Part 1 · Why Afghanistan is not a buffer
- ☐ Part 2 · Neighbours, re-wired
- ☐ Part 3 · [Title]

[ABOUT THE AUTHOR](#)

Nimra Zahid is an International Relations researcher and educator in Northampton, UK.

[More about me →](#)

Nimra Zahid

International Relations researcher and educator. Northampton, UK.

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RSCT

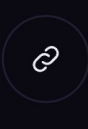
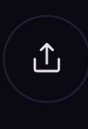
AFGHANISTAN

SERIES · PART 1 OF 3

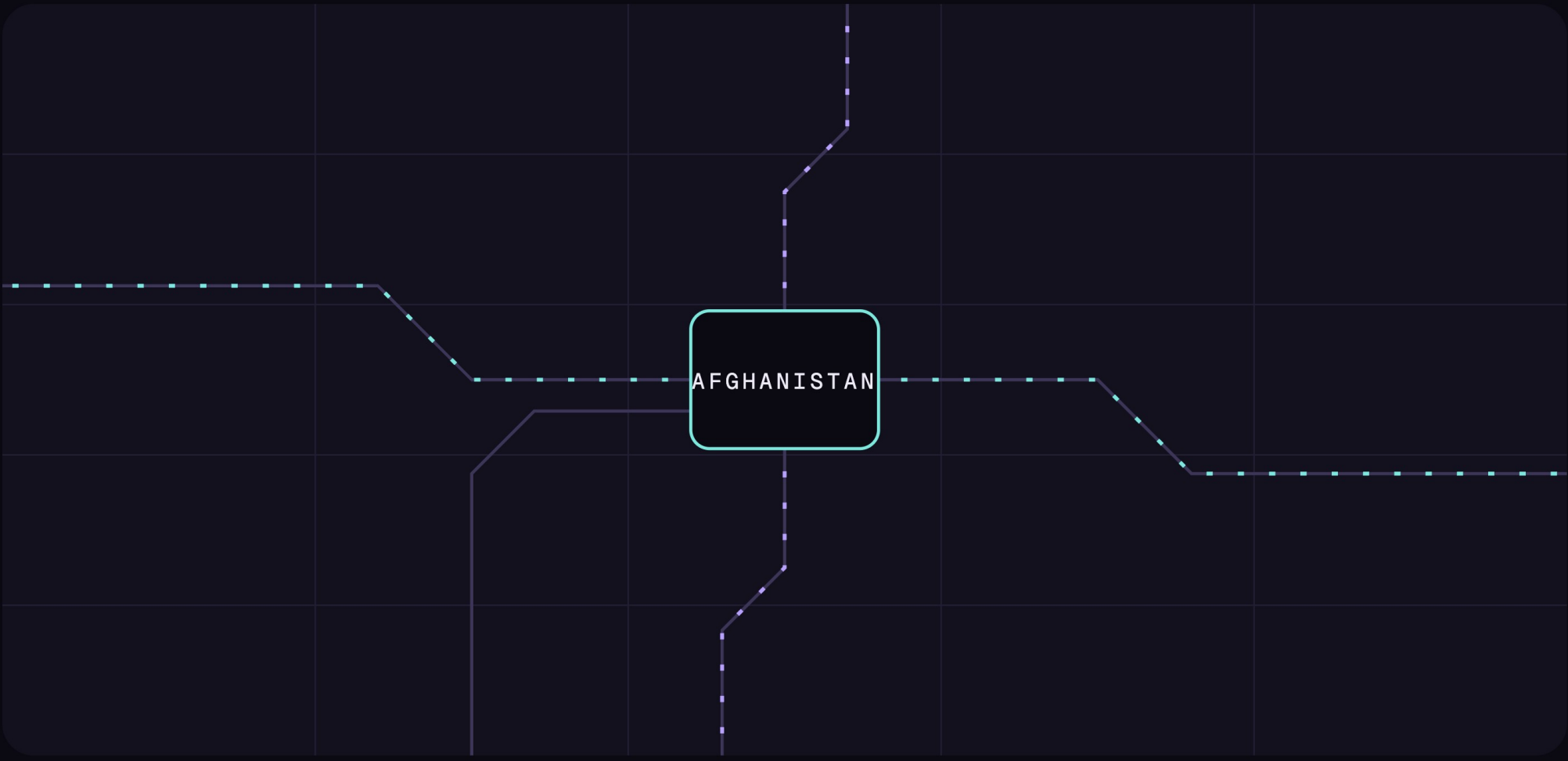
Why Afghanistan is not a buffer

A plain-language guide to Regional Security Complex Theory, and the classification my research sets out to challenge.

 **Nimra Zahid**
7 min read · [PUBLISH DATE]



CITE



An insulator is meant to stop the current. What happens when it doesn't?

In 2003, Barry Buzan and Ole Wæver published *Regions and Powers*, one of the most influential attempts to explain how security works at the level of regions. Their answer is Regional Security Complex Theory, usually shortened to RSCT.

What is a security complex?

The starting point is simple: most threats travel more easily over short distances than long ones. States therefore worry most about their neighbours, and their security concerns become bound up with one another. A regional security complex is a group of states whose security problems are so interlinked that they cannot sensibly be analysed apart. South Asia, with India and Pakistan at its centre, is a familiar example.

And what is

Share quote

Copy link to highlight

Between complexes, RSCT identifies insulators: **states that sit on the boundary between two or more complexes, facing in several directions but absorbing rather than transmitting their dynamics**. Afghanistan is one of the theory's examples, placed between South Asia, the Middle East and the post-Soviet space of Central Asia.¹

An insulator is supposed to stop the current. Afghanistan, I argue, has often been where the current starts.

Why the label matters

Labels shape analysis. If Afghanistan is treated as a buffer, what happens inside it looks like a local story, and the security of its neighbours can be studied without it. My research asks what changes if we read it instead as an instigator: a source of dynamics that travel outward into the complexes around it.

[Your strongest example from the dissertation · 1–2 paragraphs]

What comes next

This is the question I am taking into doctoral research. In the next part of this series, I look at how that outward current reaches each of Afghanistan's neighbours.

NOTES & REFERENCES

1. Barry Buzan and Ole Wæver, *Regions and Powers: The Structure of International Security* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2003).

CITE THIS ARTICLE

APAHarvardChicago

Zahid, N. ([YEAR]). Why Afghanistan is not a buffer. *Nimra Zahid*. [ARTICLE URL]

RSCT

Afghanistan

Regional security

 **Written by Nimra Zahid**
International Relations researcher and educator. I study how Afghanistan shapes the security of the regions around it.

About me →

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MORE FROM NIMRA

- NEXT IN SERIES · PART 2

Afghanistan's neighbours, re-wired

How security dynamics travel outward into the regions around Afghanistan.
- TEACHING · REFLECTION

Teaching geopolitics with care

What specialist SEMH classrooms have taught me about explaining a complicated world.

Complete the *circuit*.

I welcome conversations about doctoral research, collaboration and speaking. My interests span Afghanistan and regional security, International Relations, and research-informed inclusive education.

EMAIL

[PROFESSIONAL EMAIL]

BASED IN

Northampton, United Kingdom

ELSEWHERE

[● ORCID](#)[● LinkedIn](#)[○ Scholar · later](#)

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S1 · OPEN

YOUR MESSAGE CLOSSES THE LOOP

What is this about?

[Research & collaboration](#)[Doctoral opportunities](#)[Speaking](#)[Other](#)

Your name

Email address

Organisation (optional)

Message

Tell me about the project and where our interests meet...

Your details are used only to reply to you. Protected by an invisible spam check.



Close the circuit ·
Send

Nimra Zahid

International Relations researcher and educator. Northampton, UK.

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The *Circuit*.

A site drawn as a circuit board, because the research is about current: RSCT calls Afghanistan an insulator, and Nimra's work reads it as an instigator.

- 01

Fine lines, soft current. Elegant, never loud sci-fi.
- 02

The metaphor lives in hero, navigation and figures. Reading stays calm.
- 03

Every diagram says something true about the work.

A Colour

Ink

#0B0A12 · page

Board

#0E0C16 · figures

Surface

#13111D · cards

Hairline

#221E33 · dividers

Trace

#2B2640 · idle lines

Trace strong

#3D3659 · borders

Text

#EEEEAF6 · ≈17:1

Text muted

#A8A1BC · ≈8:1

Lilac · primary

#B9A2FF · ≈9:1

Current · live

#7EE8DF · ≈13:1

Rose · insulator

#F2A9C4 · ≈10:1

Gold · results

#E9C77B · ≈12:1

LIGHT READING MODE

Paper #FAF7F2

Ink #1E1A2B · ≈16:1

Plum #5A3990 · ≈8:1

Teal #1D7472 · ≈5:1

Ratios are against Ink (dark) or Paper (light). State is never shown by colour alone: the insulator also uses its barrier symbol and a text label.

B Type

Fraunces · display
76 / 1.02 · -0.025em

They called it an insulator. *I study the current.*

Fraunces · section
52 / 1.08 · 36 / 1.1

From insulator to instigator.

Newsreader · long-form
21 / 1.68 · 680px measure

Between complexes, RSCT identifies insulators: states that sit on the boundary between two or more complexes, absorbing rather than transmitting their dynamics.

Geist · interface
17 / 1.65 · 15 UI

Over ten years teaching across Pakistan and England, from undergraduate International Relations to specialist SEMH provision.

Geist Mono · labels
12 min · +0.14em · caps

U1 · INTERNATIONAL RELATIONS × EDUCATION · FIG. 1 · STATE · INSTIGATOR

C Circuit primitives

Trace · idle

2px, 45° bends only. Connects sections and figures.

Trace · live

Dash 4/16, 1.4s linear. Static and lit when motion is reduced.

Pad · off / on

Regions, timeline points, section markers.

Chip

Afghanistan only. The one component at the centre of every figure.

Barrier · insulator

Rose double bar. Marks where RSCT says the current stops.

Switch · open / closed

Contact only. Sending a message closes it.

Lamp · branch

Teaching only. One lit lamp per learner in a parallel circuit.

Signal lane

CV timing diagram. High while a role or degree is active.

D Designators

- U1–U7

Pages: Home, About, Research, Teaching, CV, Writing, Contact
- J1–J4

Sections within a page, joined by the left-hand trace
- E · R · T · L

CV entries: education, research, teaching, leadership
- FIG. n

Diagrams, numbered across the site
- F · M · P

Findings, modules, principles

E Motion & access

- Current flows only on traces. Nothing else animates on a loop.
- State changes fade over 0.6s. Reduced motion: every trace shown lit and still.
- Text 12px minimum; touch targets 44px minimum.
- Focus ring: 2px Current, 2px offset, on every control.
- Every figure has a text description; diagrams are abstract, never maps.

F Components

BUTTONS

Primary

Secondary

Teaching

SEGMENTED · CHIPS

Insulator

Instigator

RSCT

MERIT

FIELD · FOCUS

Email address

name@university.ac.uk

● U1 · IR × EDUCATION

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I'm Nimra Zahid, an International Relations researcher and educator. I ask what changes when Afghanistan is read not as a buffer between regions, but as a driver of their security.

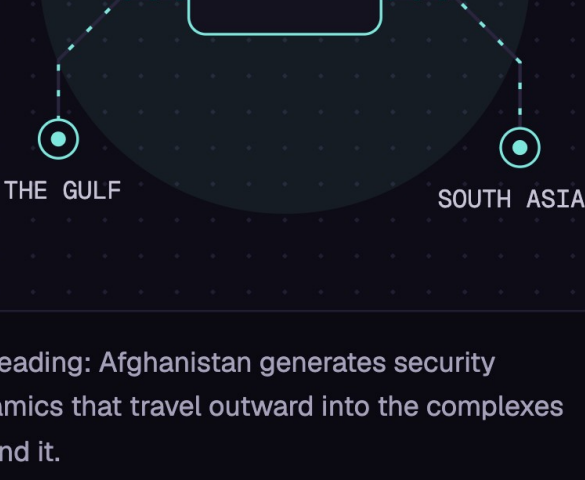
MA IR (Merit) · MPhil IR

Educator since 2015 · Northampton, UK

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Insulator

Instigator



My reading: Afghanistan generates security dynamics that travel outward into the complexes around it.

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Research and teaching run on the same current.

R1 · RESEARCH

Regional security & Afghanistan

Why Afghanistan should be understood as an instigator, not simply an insulator, in its regional security complex.

[Explore the argument →](#)

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From insulator to *instigator*.

2018 · MPhil THESIS

Russia, Afghanistan & regional stability

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Afghanistan, Turkey & the Global War on Terror

2024 · MA DISSERTATION · MERIT

Deconstructing Afghanistan's role in RSCT

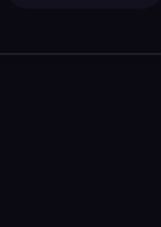
NEXT · DOCTORAL RESEARCH

Testing the instigator thesis

J3 · LATEST WRITING

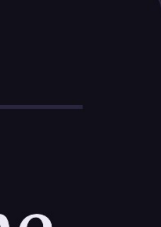
RSCT · 7 MIN

Why Afghanistan is not a buffer



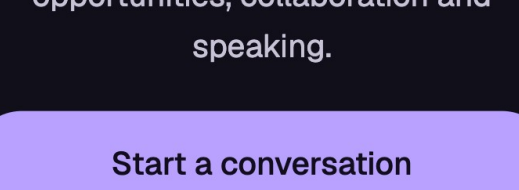
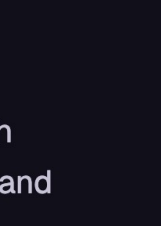
REGIONAL SECURITY · DRAFT

Afghanistan's neighbours, re-wired



TEACHING · DRAFT

Teaching geopolitics with care



Complete the *circuit*.

Open to doctoral research opportunities, collaboration and speaking.

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Nimra Zahid

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RSCT

PART 1 OF 3

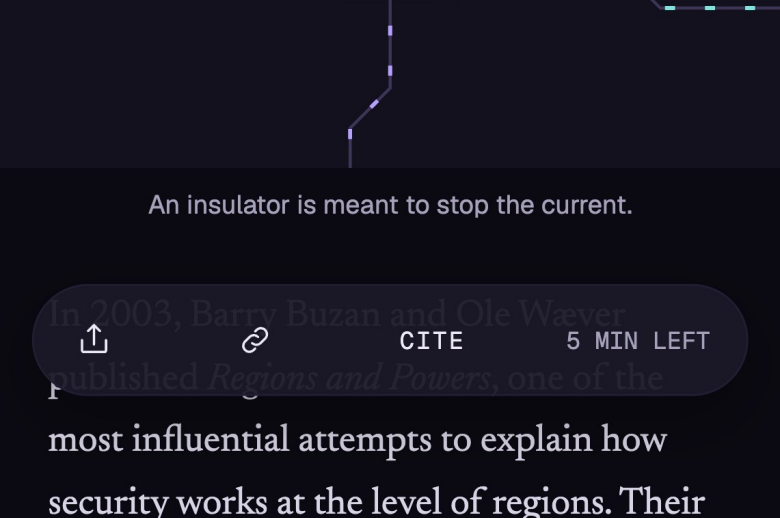
Why Afghanistan is not a buffer

A plain-language guide to Regional Security Complex Theory, and the classification my research sets out to challenge.

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What is a security complex?

Most threats travel more easily over short distances than long ones. States therefore worry most about their neighbours, and their security concerns become bound up with one another. A regional security complex is a group of states whose security problems cannot sensibly be analysed apart.

And what is an insulator?

Between complexes, RSCT identifies insulators: states on the boundary between complexes that absorb rather than transmit their dynamics. Afghanistan is one of the theory’s examples, placed between South Asia, the Middle East and Central Asia.¹

NOTE 1 · TAP TO OPEN

Barry Buzan and Ole Wæver, *Regions and Powers* (Cambridge University Press, 2003).

An insulator is supposed to stop the current. Afghanistan, I argue, has often been where the current starts.

Why the label matters

Labels shape analysis. If Afghanistan is treated as a buffer, what happens inside it looks like a local story. My research asks what changes if we read it instead as an instigator: a source of dynamics that travel outward into the complexes around it.

What comes next

This is the question I am taking into doctoral research. In Part 2, I look at how that outward current reaches each of Afghanistan’s neighbours.

NOTES & REFERENCES

1. Barry Buzan and Ole Wæver, *Regions and Powers: The Structure of International Security* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2003).

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